

Introduction

引言 yǐn yán

Our project aims to discuss and analyze the cultural developments of Cleveland, Ohio, influenced by Chinese culture. Cleveland is home to many different nationalities after a large wave of immigration began in the early 1800s. Places like the Westside Market became places where food and people from around the world could interact and work. After some time in the city, small, neighborly sodalities formed. Eventually, the community of Asia town came to be.

Li Wah restaurant (丽华酒家) is a Chinese restaurant in Cleveland that serves traditional Chinese dishes. It is a place where Chinese culture is celebrated and shared with the community through traditional meals. Many people make trips from out of state to get a taste of the foods that they grew up eating. They help to expand non-Chinese customers' perception of Chinese food. The meals are served family-style, where everyone shares the dish in line with Chinese culture, which values using food to build relationships with those around the community.

Family Story and Restaurant History

家庭故事和餐馆历史

jiā tíng gù shì hé cǎn guǎn lì shǐ

Widespread Asian immigration to Cleveland began in the 1860s, when immigrants from the West Coast came to escape anti-immigrant sentiment. By the 1920s, the Chinese population had condensed onto East 22nd Street and Rockwell Avenue. This area became known as Chinatown, and the population skyrocketed throughout the 20th century (largely due to the communist takeover of China in 1949). By the late 20th to early 21st century, the area's diversity had increased, and it was expanded and renamed Asia Town. There are a few plazas throughout the area that feature restaurants, Asian-food specialty grocery stores, and other shops. Inside the Asia Town Plaza, a Cantonese-style restaurant called "Li Wah restaurant" can be found.

The restaurant symbolizes the value of family in Chinese culture and has been passed down to the current owner, Ed Hom, from his late mother, Donna Hom, who came to Ohio in 1960 from Hong Kong. Founded in 1991 by Donna Hon and later managed by Ed Hom, Li Wah has become a significant part of AsiaTown and Cleveland.

Community Impact

社区影响 shè qū yǐng xiǎng

The Asia Town Plaza (which houses Li Wah) hosts many Asian cultural events that bring together Asian ethnicities. During the Chinese Spring Festival, people witness traditional dances from different cultures and dine at Li Wah. People from across Cleveland come together for these events to experience Asian cultures.

It is difficult to overstate Mr. Hom's impact in the immediate area and the local community. Originally, AsiaTown hosted a traditional Spring Festival for years. As more Asian ethnicities moved into the area and participated in the Festival, it quickly became the Asian Festival, with almost all of his properties opened for free, as long as volunteers aided in the functions for smooth operation.

This grassroots festival, held during Asia Pacific American Heritage Month in May, highlights the growing identity of Cleveland's AsiaTown. In 2025, they celebrated the 16th year of the festival and attracted over 100+ vendors and exhibitors.

亚洲文化节每年五月“亚太裔美国人传统月”举办，体现亚洲裔在克利夫兰获得的文化认同不断提升。2025年迎来第16届，吸引了100多家商户和参展者。

Language and Labor Shape Authentic Experience

语言和员工塑造真实体验

yǔ yán hé yuán gōng sù zhào zhēn shí tǐ yàn

In the Li Wah restaurant, service is usually conducted in English and Chinese, in Mandarin and Cantonese. However, there will be people who speak some other dialect, such as the Taishan dialect (台山话) and the Fujian/Hokkien (福建话/闽南语). These other dialects can simply be a niche addition to the environment, which will lead to a more niche clientele, or they can be a necessary condition, depending on the population that commonly visits the restaurant!

丽华餐厅通常以英语、普通话和广东话为主。也有人使用其他方言，比如台山话或、闽南话。

Líhuá Cǎntīng tōngcháng yǐ Yīngyǔ, pǔtōnghuà hé Guǎngdōnghuà wéi zhǔ. Yě yǒu rén shíyòng qítā fāngyán, bǐrú Tàishānhuà huò Mǐnnánhuà.

At Li Wah, the restaurant we visited, managers tightly manage employees, and the hiring process is highly specific. Edward Hom has a strict policy and puts in an astounding amount of effort to make each part of the restaurant in Cleveland as authentic as possible. He noted the importance of the workers to the restaurant, and they are the backbone. It takes considerable time and effort to get a job as a restaurant cook. High standards for the cooks ensure the kitchen's food authenticity. So much that he makes every effort to hire and offer visa options for chefs directly from Hong Kong (香港) and Guangzhou (广州). He even goes so far as to say that they don't turn people away from wanting a job, but they will never reach the point of becoming a chef if they don't meet those conditions. But the employees will always be treated like family, no matter the position within the establishment.

We interviewed a customer named Carmen, who coincided with the claim of authenticity. Having recently traveled to different regions in China, he had eaten the food in each. He said that each region had different tasting food, but he felt the food of Li Wah reflected the Chinese food he'd eaten in China.

Resources:

<https://www.cleveland19.com/2021/01/23/donna-hom-cleveland-pioneer-business-woman-dies/>

<https://liwahrestaurant.com/about-us>

<https://clevelandhistorical.org/items/show/974>

<https://www.wrhs.org/do-see/collections/published-unpublished-materials/immigration-and-migration>

<https://www.asiatowncleveland.org/about/>

<https://www.deepl.com/en/translator>

<https://www.thesprucecats.com/the-origin-of-finger-tapping-694328/#:~:text=The%20next%20time%20you%27re,person%20who%20poured%20your%20tea,https://clevelandasianfestival.org/2025/about/>

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Qianlong_Emperor

Tea Culture in a Multicultural City

多元化城市中的中国茶文化

duō yuán huà chéng shì zhōng de zhōng guó chá wén huà

The cultural differences in food don't seem to pose a major challenge to reconciling the two practices between staff and customers. However, Chinese people really don't mind helping others learn, especially when those from other backgrounds approach it with an open mind, are willing to be corrected, and want a close-to-home experience. For example, it is customary for Chinese dinners to drink tea (茶) during meals. When someone pours tea for you, Westerners typically express thanks verbally or with a nod. In Chinese culture, however, one lightly taps two fingers on the table twice as a gesture of gratitude -- no verbal means of appreciation are even expected! This is a manner to avoid interrupting the flow of conversation at the table.

A legend that the tradition originated to Emperor QianLong (乾隆皇帝 1735-1799 A.D) of Qing Dynasty(清代). He loved to travel and quietly "observed" his people, but he was especially interested in tea practices, specifically in leaning across the table to pour tea without spilling a drop. He could never replicate it in the same way, and he decided to practice more. However, custom demanded that people bow before the Emperor. This, of course, would ruin his disguise. Instead, the Emperor told his companions to "bow" with the middle three fingers each time he refilled their cup - two fingers represented the prostrate arms and another the bowed head. Nowadays, tapping the table is a way of paying silent thanks when someone pours your tea.

At Li Wah, they are not particularly concerned with accommodating Western culture and altering Chinese culture to better suit it. The atmosphere they intend to convey is one of heavy Chinese authenticity; The balance of the area lies in its ability to hold strongly to tradition and elicit a desire among people to eat comfortably in one place that puts the focus entirely on customers and almost no emphasis on profit. The service and attention to customers truly reflect this notion in real time.



Interviewed Mr.Ed Hom and his employee.